

Inchcolm Island & Forth Bridge - Kids

UK Family Tour

Where the River Turns Into the Sea

Look out at the water all around your boat. It looks like the sea, doesn't it? Big and grey and salty, with waves and seabirds. But here is a secret. This isn't quite the sea, and it isn't quite a river either. It's something in between, and it even has its own special name. It's called a firth.

Here is what that means. A river is born high up in the hills, small enough to jump across. As it flows it grows and grows, until near the very end it gets so enormous, and so wide, and so full of salty water from the ocean sneaking in, that it stops being a river at all and turns into this. A firth. A firth is the giant open mouth of a river, wide enough to swallow the sea. And this one is called the Firth of Forth.

The funny thing is, if you could stand here two thousand years ago, the water would look almost exactly the same. This firth is old, older than any castle, older than any king. And for all that time it has been like a giant watery road. Kings sailed across it. Armies were scared of it. Monks rowed little boats out to hidden islands. Ships carried wool and coal and wine up and down it. The whole city of Edinburgh grew up right beside it, because this was the best road in Scotland, and it was made entirely of water.

So today you are not just going to an island. You are sailing on one of the most important roads in the whole country. Feel the boat rock under you. Taste the salt in the air. And keep looking, because this watery road is absolutely stuffed with secrets, and I am going to show them to you one by one.

Islands That Were Churches, Forts and Prisons

Now count the islands. Go on, look all around the firth and see how many little islands and rocky lumps you can spot poking out of the water. There are lots of them. And here is the amazing part. Almost every single one used to have a job.

Think about it. An island is a bit of land with water all the way around it. That makes it two things at once. It's safe, because nobody can sneak up on you without a boat. And it's a trap, because if you're stuck there, you can't get off. People all through history looked at these islands and thought, aha, I know exactly what to do with that.

Long, long ago, holy men called monks looked at the islands and thought, peace and quiet, perfect for praying. So they rowed out and built little churches, far away from noisy villages, with nothing around them but sea and sky and squawking birds. The island you are heading to, Inchcolm, was one of these. Monks lived out there for hundreds of years.

But other people looked at the very same islands and had very different ideas. Soldiers thought, what a brilliant fort. An island right in the middle of the water could watch every enemy ship and blast it with cannons. So some islands got covered in guns and walls. And some islands got an even spookier job. They became prisons, or places to send people who were terribly sick, rowed out and left there so their illness could not spread to everyone on land. Imagine being dropped on a lonely rock in the middle of the firth, all on your own. Brrr.

So as you sail past each island today, play a game. Ask it, quietly, were you a peaceful church, a mighty fort, or a spooky prison? And here is the twist. Some of them, believe it or not, were all three, at different times in their long, strange lives.

How to Get Across When the Water's in the Way

Here is a puzzle that people worried about for hundreds and hundreds of years. The big city of Edinburgh is on this side of the firth. But there is lovely land on the other side too, right across the water. So how on earth do you get across?

The firth is brilliant if you want to travel along it in a boat. But it is really annoying if you just want to get to the other side, because there is a whole mile of cold, deep, wavy salt water in the way. You can't jump it. You can't walk it. So what do you do?

For a very, very long time there was only one answer. Get in a little boat and row like mad. Monks rowed themselves out to their islands. And people who wanted to cross the firth climbed into wooden ferry boats and were rowed all the way over, freezing cold, getting splashed, taking ages and ages. There was even a special crossing used by a queen long ago, and the town there is still called Queensferry because of her. But when a big storm blew in, everybody just had to wait, sometimes for days and days, until the water calmed down. No crossing today. Sorry.

And then, a bit more than a hundred years ago, people had an incredible idea. What if you didn't cross the water at all? What if you built something so gigantic that you could step right over the top of it? And they did. They built the enormous red bridge you can see, so strong and so huge that trains have been thundering across the sky on it ever since. You'll hear its whole story later. But just think about it for a second. A tiny monk shivering in a rowing boat, and a giant train roaring over a bridge in the clouds. Both of them were trying to solve the exact same puzzle. How do you beat the water and get across?

The Big Red Bridge Made of 6.5 Million Rivets

Before your boat even leaves, look up at the giant red bridge marching across the water on huge steel legs. That's the Forth Bridge, opened in 1890, and it was the biggest thing humans had ever built out of steel — fifty-three thousand tonnes of it, held together by about six and a half million rivets, each one heated glowing-hot and hammered in by hand. It took seven years and about four and a half thousand workers. The last rivet, a gold-plated one, was tapped in by the future King Edward the Seventh. Why does it look so massively overbuilt? Because eleven years earlier, a big Scottish railway bridge over the River Tay collapsed in a storm while a train was crossing, and everyone aboard died. Britain was so shocked that the Forth Bridge's engineers made it not just strong, but visibly, obviously, unmistakably strong — so every passenger could see with their own eyes that it would never fall. Trains still rumble across it today, about two hundred every day, one hundred thirty-six years later. In Britain, when a job seems to never end, people say it's "like painting the Forth Bridge" — because painting it took so long that when crews finished, legend says, they had to start again at the other end. Your boat sails right underneath it. Wave to the trains.

Related listening: Two great Victorian bridges, opened four years apart: one dressed as a castle, one all bare steel. Listen back — "A Bridge That Opens Like a Drawbridge" (Tower Bridge, Day 3).

The Three Men and the Chairs

Here is how the engineers proved the bridge would work, and you can try it yourself later. Before the bridge was even finished, a clever engineer named Benjamin Baker wanted to show everyone that its funny diamond shape was actually incredibly strong. So he did something brilliant. He sat two grown men on two chairs, a little way apart, and told each of them to stretch out their arms and hold a broomstick, with a big heavy pile of bricks stacked beside them. Then, in the empty space between the two men, held up by nothing but their outstretched arms, a third man sat down in mid air. And he did not fall. That is the whole secret of the Forth Bridge, shown with three people. The two men on the chairs are the bridge's towers. Their stretched-out arms, pulling hard, are the steel bars along the top. Their bodies and the broomsticks, pushing and squeezing, are the giant steel tubes along the bottom. And the piles of bricks are the heavy ends that anchor the whole thing down so it can never tip over. The man floating in the middle? That's the train, crossing safely. Now for the best part. The man they chose to sit in the middle was a young engineer named Kaichi Watanabe, who had travelled all the way from Japan to help build the bridge. They picked him on purpose, as a thank you to the countries of the East, where builders had used this clever reaching-arm idea for hundreds and hundreds of years. So next time you are with two grown-ups and a few cushions, give it a go. Two people on chairs with their arms stretched out, and a smaller person perched carefully between them. Can you feel how the arms have to pull while the bodies push? The clever thing is that the two men are not really lifting the weight at all. They are pulling and pushing against each other, and against their piles of bricks, and that quiet battle of pulling and pushing is exactly what holds the middle man up in the air. A real bridge does the same trick, only with steel instead of arms. If nobody wobbles over, congratulations. You have just turned yourselves into the Forth Bridge.

How Tall, How Long, How Heavy

Let's play a game of how big. Look at the two enormous arches that make up the middle of the bridge. Each one reaches more than five hundred metres across the water, which is longer than five football pitches laid end to end, all in a single jump, with no legs holding up the middle. When the bridge opened in 1890,

no bridge anywhere in the whole wide world could leap further in one go. It stayed the world champion for twenty seven whole years. Now look at how high up the train track is. It runs about forty six metres above the sea, as tall as a building with fifteen floors. The builders made it that high on purpose, so that the tallest sailing ships and warships could glide underneath without their masts bumping the bottom. And here is a sneaky secret. The legs in the very middle of the bridge are not standing on the seabed at all. They are standing on a whole little island, called Inchgarvie, sitting right in the middle of the water, which the builders used like a giant stepping stone. Then there is the paint. For more than a hundred years, painting this gigantic bridge took so long that the very moment the painters reached the far end, they had to go straight back to the start and begin all over again, forever and ever. That is why people used to say a job that never ends is like painting the Forth Bridge. But not anymore. A while ago the bridge got a coat of super-tough, space-age paint, the same kind that protects oil platforms far out at sea, and it should last for twenty five years or more. So the painters, at long last, after more than a century of climbing about in the wind and the rain, finally got to go home. One more number to boggle your brain. The whole bridge is held together by about six and a half million rivets, which are like giant metal buttons, and if you tried to count them out loud, one every second, without ever stopping to sleep or eat, it would take you more than two months. As you sail underneath, give the old bridge, and its tired painters, a wave too.

Three Bridges in a Row

As your boat slips through, do a quick count. How many bridges cross the water here? The answer is three, and they are like three brothers of very different ages, standing in a line. The nearest one, the big red one made of steel diamonds, is the oldest brother. It's the railway bridge, built in 1890, and only trains are allowed to cross it. Next along is a bridge that looks completely different, hanging from two tall towers on long swooping cables, a bit like a giant skipping rope stretched across the water. That is the road bridge, built in 1964, for cars and buses and lorries. And then there is the newest brother of all, gleaming and white, with three pointed towers and cables fanning out like the strings of a harp. That one opened in 2017. So the oldest bridge here and the newest bridge here were built a hundred and twenty seven years apart, yet they stand right next to each other, sharing the same view. Why build three bridges in one place? Well, first came the trains, so people built a bridge just for trains. Then along came motorcars, and cars cannot drive on a railway, so they built a second bridge just for the road. But after fifty years of heavy lorries thundering across, the road bridge grew tired, and its thick cables started to wear out deep inside, where nobody could see. So rather than risk it, they built the beautiful white bridge to take over the job. Three bridges, three different jobs, three different times, all crossing the exact same stretch of water. See if you can point to all three, and remember the trick. Red is the oldest, and white is the newest, with the cars in between. Here is a game for the boat. Imagine you could travel in time just by hopping from one bridge to the next. Step onto the red one and you are back in the days of steam trains and top hats. Step onto the middle one and it is the nineteen sixties. Step onto the white one and you are almost in today. Three bridges, and each one is like a doorway into a different age.

The Island of the Monks

Inchcolm is called the “Iona of the East” — a tiny holy island where monks lived for hundreds of years. The story begins in 1123, when King Alexander the First of Scotland was caught in a violent storm crossing the Forth and shipwrecked here. A hermit — a monk living alone on the island in a tiny cell, surviving on shellfish and the milk of one cow — sheltered the king for three days. The grateful king promised to build a monastery on the island, and Inchcolm Abbey was born. Because it’s on an island, the abbey escaped the destruction that ruined most Scottish monasteries, so it’s the best-preserved one in Scotland — you can climb the tower’s narrow spiral stairs, explore the echoing chapter house with its stone dome, and creep along the actual dark cloister passages where monks walked, prayed and worked eight hundred years ago. Try the echo in the chapter house — one clap. Monk life was tough: they woke in the middle of the night for prayers, every night, forever. But island life had other problems too: pirates! English raiders attacked the island monks several times, stealing everything, including once — the story goes — a beloved statue. Legend says the raiders’ ship promptly hit trouble, and the frightened sailors brought it back. Don’t mess with the island.

The Island in a Shakespeare Play

Here is something almost nobody knows about this tiny island. It has a starring role in one of the most famous plays ever written. About four hundred years ago, a writer named William Shakespeare wrote a spooky, thrilling play called *Macbeth*, all about Scottish kings and witches and battles in the dark. And right near the beginning, he mentions a real island by name. This one. In the play, an army of invaders from Norway has just lost a huge battle against the Scots. Their soldiers lie dead on the ground, and the Norwegian king wants to bury them properly. But the Scots say no, not until you pay us first. And where do they make the beaten Norwegians hand over their treasure, ten thousand coins of it, before they are allowed to bury their dead? At Saint Colme’s Inch, which is the old name for this very island, the island of Saint Columba. Now, that particular story is probably just a legend, not something that truly happened. But real invaders certainly did come here long ago. Fierce Viking raiders sailed these grey waters in their longships and attacked little holy islands exactly like this one. And here is the funny twist that ties it all together. Hundreds of years ago, a monk who actually lived right here on Inchcolm wrote an enormous history book about Scotland, full of kings and battles. Bits of that book were copied out and passed along, year after year, until at last they reached Shakespeare himself, and helped give him the ideas for his play. So a monk on this quiet rock helped spark a story, and the story ended up on stages all over the world, with the island’s own name spoken out loud inside it. Imagine that. An actor on a stage in faraway London, saying the name of the little island you are sailing toward right now. And here is a bonus puzzle for the play. Shakespeare says the Norwegians paid in dollars, but dollars had not even been invented yet in those ancient days, so he got that bit wrong by hundreds of years. Writers make mistakes too. But he got one thing exactly right. This island really was a famous, special place where important people longed to be buried, close to a holy saint. So when you land, you are stepping onto a spot that a great playwright thought worth putting into a play.

Secrets to Find in the Ruins

Let’s go on a treasure hunt through the abbey, because this is no ordinary ruin. Most old Scottish monasteries are just broken, tumbledown walls now, but this one still has real rooms with real roofs that you can walk right inside, and it hides some brilliant secrets. Secret number one, find the eight-sided room called the chapter house. It still has its stone roof, and it makes an amazing echo. Stand in the middle, say one word or clap once, and listen to it bounce around the stone. This is where the monks sat

every single morning to be given their jobs for the day. Secret number two, walk along the covered stone corridors that run around the square garden. They are called the cloister, and this is the most complete cloister left anywhere in Scotland, the very same sheltered walkways the monks paced up and down eight hundred years ago. Secret number three, and this is the best of all, look for a real painting on the wall, tucked into a stone nook, that is more than seven hundred years old. It shows a line of people in hoods, walking slowly in a funeral. Once upon a time, almost every wall in here was covered in bright colours and pictures, and this little faded patch is one of the only bits that survived. Secret number four, find the tiny stone hut where a hermit once lived all alone with just one cow, because that lonely little hut is how the whole abbey began. And finally, if your legs are feeling brave, climb the twisty tower stairs all the way to the top for the best view of the entire day. Here is the big question to solve. Why did this abbey survive when so many others were smashed to pieces? The answer is easy. It sits on an island. When people came along wanting to knock the monasteries down and carry off the stones, they took one look at all that cold water in the way, and decided it simply was not worth the boat trip.

The Viking Stone Shaped Like a House

Here is a challenge for you on the island. Go into the little visitor centre and hunt for a long, heavy stone that is older than the whole abbey. Older than the tower, older than the echoey chapter house, older than everything. This stone was carved more than a thousand years ago, back in the time of the Vikings, and it is one of the coolest things on the whole island.

It is called a hogback stone, and it is a Viking grave marker. But here is the amazing part. It is carved to look like a tiny house. Really. The Vikings who made it wanted to give the dead person a little stone home, so they shaped the top like the curved roof of a Viking hall, and along the sloping sides they carved rows and rows of roof tiles, overlapping like the scales of a fish. And right at the end, look closely, there is a fierce carved animal, a beast, that looks like it is guarding the roof, just like the snarling dragons the Vikings put on the fronts of their ships and their houses. Imagine that. A stone house for someone who died, watched over by a stone dragon.

But there is a twist. On one side of the stone somebody carved a man with his arms stretched right out and a spear beside him, and on the other side there is a cross. A cross means this person was a Christian. So this was not one of the wild raiders you might picture, with a horned helmet and an axe. This was a Viking who had settled down, who lived here quietly and prayed, and who was buried on this holy island a really long time ago, about two hundred years before the monks even turned up to build their abbey.

Because that is the thing about the Vikings that lots of people forget. Yes, some of them raided and robbed. But many of them sailed over, liked what they found, stayed, became farmers, married, had children, and turned Christian, and they buried their families under these funny, wonderful house-shaped stones. So say hello to this one. And keep it in your memory, because later on your trip, when you visit the great Viking city at York, you are going to meet these people all over again. You just happened to meet your very first real Viking right here, on a little island in Scotland.

Seals, Seabirds and Secret War Tunnels

Keep watch on the crossing: these waters are full of wildlife. Grey seals love to lounge on the rocks and buoys near the island like fat bananas — the boat crew usually knows where they're hanging out today, and you might see their dog-like heads pop out of the water to inspect your boat. In early summer, puffins zip past like flying potatoes with orange feet. One warning about July: it's seagull chick season. Parts of the island are guarded by nesting gulls who dive-bomb anyone who walks too close to their fluffy chicks. Follow the marked paths, and if a gull swoops you, raise your hand or a hat above your head — they aim for the highest point. Consider it the island's air force. Now here's the surprise: this holy island of peaceful monks is also a fortress. Because Inchcolm sits right in the sea lane to Edinburgh and the naval bases, it was armed to the teeth in both World Wars — gun batteries, searchlights, barracks, and a network of tunnels cut through the island's spine that you can walk through today. A hundred soldiers lived here where monks once prayed. Explore the dark tunnel — it's genuinely spooky — then have your picnic on the beach where, eight hundred years apart, both monks and soldiers watched the same water for trouble.

Related listening: The same war on two fronts: London's bunker and the fortress island guarding the Forth. Listen back — "London at War" (Churchill War Rooms, Day 6).

The Soldiers' Island

You already know that this peaceful island of monks once turned into a fortress. But let's find out what the soldiers actually did here, because it is a proper adventure story. The soldiers first arrived in 1915, during the First World War, and they had one big, important job. They had to guard the doorway to the river, so that enemy ships and sneaky submarines could not slip upstream and attack the navy. To do it, they packed this little island with eight guns that could fire really, really fast, some of them right up near the top of the hill, pointing in every direction so that nothing could possibly get past. At night, they switched on enormous searchlights, far brighter than any car headlight, and swept the beams across the black water, hunting for the shadow of an enemy boat trying to creep by in the dark. They even stretched a giant net, called a boom, all the way across the water between the islands, like an underwater fence to trap submarines. And here is the really clever part. To carry heavy boxes of ammunition to the guns without being seen, they dug a tunnel straight through the middle of the hill, so the soldiers could hurry through in secret from one side to the other. That is the dark, spooky tunnel you can walk through today, so remember, real soldiers once rushed along it carrying shells. About a hundred soldiers lived out here on this windy little island, sleeping in huts, keeping watch over the water day and night, in the very same place where, hundreds of years before them, gentle monks had knelt down to pray. Same island, same grey view, but a completely different job. Think how strange it must have been. In the daytime the soldiers could look up and see the ruined abbey, all quiet and holy, and at night they stood beside their guns in the freezing wind, listening for the rumble of an enemy engine out on the water. As you explore, see if you can spot where the big guns once stood, and where the searchlights once blazed out across the dark.

Where the Animals Live

The Firth of Forth is like a huge wildlife motorway, and the islands around you are the busy stopping places where the animals rest and raise their babies. Take the grey seals you might spot lolling about on the rocks. In summer they are mostly just relaxing and fishing, but in the autumn they gather in enormous crowds on quiet islands and beaches to have their pups. And a baby seal is born wearing a coat of fluffy white fur, so soft and fluffy that it cannot even swim at first. Its mother feeds it thick, creamy milk until it grows fat and round, and only then does it lose the white fluff, grow a sleek waterproof

coat, and finally slip into the sea. Then there are the puffins, those little birds with the bright rainbow beaks. Puffins do not build nests up in trees. Instead they dig burrows down in the ground, like rabbit holes, on grassy islands nearby, and they only visit in the summer to raise a single chick, which has the wonderful name of a puffling. Once summer ends, they fly far, far out to sea and stay there all winter long. Further out toward the open water is a very special place called the Bass Rock, a whole island that looks as though it is covered in snow. But it is not snow at all. It is tens of thousands of big white birds called gannets, so many of them squashed together that they turn the whole rock white. It is the biggest gathering of gannets on the entire planet. And if you keep your eyes on the waves, you might even catch a dolphin or a porpoise rolling past. So watch the water carefully. Every splash, every bobbing head, every whirring pair of wings could be one of the island's neighbours, heading home. And here is why all these creatures crowd into the same corner of the sea. The Firth of Forth is packed with fish, which is a giant free dinner for seals and puffins and gannets alike, and the little rocky islands make safe places to rest and hide from danger. So this really is a wildlife city, with the fish as its food shops and the islands as its houses. You just happen to be visiting on ferry day.

The Day the Bombs Fell from the Sky

Now let me tell you about the most dramatic day this stretch of water ever saw. It happened right here, over the bridge and the firth you are sailing on, on the sixteenth of October, 1939, near the very start of the Second World War.

That morning, twelve German bomber planes came roaring in from the sea. They were hunting the Royal Navy's warships, the big grey ships gathered near the bridge, and they carried heavy bombs under their wings. It was the very first time in the whole war that German planes had come to attack Britain itself, and out of everywhere in the entire country, they came here first, to this water.

But they did not have the sky to themselves. Scotland's own fighter planes, fast little Spitfires flown by pilots from Glasgow and from Edinburgh, came screaming up to meet them. And then something incredible happened right over these waves. A real dogfight, planes twisting and diving and chasing each other through the clouds, engines howling, guns rattling, all directly above the bridge.

And here is the part that gives me shivers. Ordinary people on the ground watched the whole thing with their own eyes. Folk in Edinburgh leaned out of their windows. People on the shore stopped and stared straight up, mouths open, at the tiny planes wheeling far overhead, because nobody yet had learned to run and hide. It was like watching a film, except it was completely real. By the end of it, two of the German planes had been shot down into the cold sea, the first enemy planes ever brought down over Britain in the whole war.

It was not all exciting, though. Some sailors on the ships below were killed that day, and that is the sad, true part of the story. But think about this. Remember the soldiers who built all those guns and searchlights on Inchcolm to stop enemy ships sneaking up the water? On that October morning, the danger did not come creeping along the water at all. It came screaming out of the sky, from a kind of machine those first soldiers, watching for submarines, could barely have dreamed of. The world had changed, and it changed right over the island you are about to explore.

The Queen's Own Ferry Boat

Here is a question. Why is the town where you got on the boat called Queensferry? Because there really was a queen, and there really was a ferry, and this is her spot.

Look at the water. This is the narrowest place in the whole wide river, the easiest place to hop from one side to the other, which is exactly why they built the bridges here and why, for a thousand years, people have crossed right here. And nearly a thousand years ago, long before any bridge, a kind queen called Margaret set up a boat to carry travellers across the water. And the best bit? She made it free. You did not need a single coin to ride the Queen's Ferry.

That is how the town got its name. There is South Queensferry, where you started, and North Queensferry on the far shore, and even the newest bridge is called the Queensferry Crossing, all named after one queen and her free little boat.

Boats kept crossing here for about nine hundred years, all the way until the road bridge finally opened in 1964 and took over the job. So your boat today, the Maid of the Forth, is like the great-great-great-grandchild of the queen's own ferry. Except you get to cross it just for the fun of it.

The Queen Who Gave Everyone a Free Ride

Let me tell you about Queen Margaret, because she is the reason this whole town has her name, and her story begins with a shipwreck.

Nearly a thousand years ago, Margaret was a princess, born into the royal family of England. But when enemies took over her country, her family had to escape by sea in a hurry. The story goes that a great storm blew their ship far to the north and washed them ashore right here, on the shore of Scotland, at a little bay that is still called Saint Margaret's Hope to this very day. And who should she meet in Scotland but the King of Scots himself, a tough warrior king named Malcolm. The two of them married, and the runaway princess became a queen.

Now, Margaret was famous for being kind and good, so kind that hundreds of years later the church made her a saint. She loved to help poor people, and she wanted travellers called pilgrims, people making long journeys to holy places to pray, to be able to cross this river safely on their way. But crossing a wide, cold, stormy river in those days was scary and it cost money, and lots of people did not have any.

So the queen fixed it. She set up a ferry boat across the water, and she paid for it herself, so that anyone could ride across for free. She even built cosy rest houses on both shores, with food kept ready, so tired travellers could warm up and eat before or after the crossing. And gentle monks did the rowing. She crossed here so many times, going back and forth to her favourite town of Dunfermline, that everyone started calling it the Queen's Ferry.

And that name stuck like glue. Long, long after Margaret was gone, the towns on both sides were still called Queensferry, and they still are today, nearly a thousand years later. Just think. A kind thing a queen did for strangers, so long ago, is still written on the map, and it is still the name of the place where you climbed aboard your boat this morning. That is a pretty amazing way to be remembered.

Nine Hundred Years of Boats

Close your eyes for a second and imagine all the different people who have crossed this exact bit of water, right where your boat is chugging along now. Because the ferry here did not run for just a few years. It ran for about nine hundred years. That is such a long time it is hard to squeeze inside your head.

At the very start there were little wooden rowing boats, with monks pulling on the oars. Then came sailing boats, leaning over in the wind. Much later came puffing steam boats with smoke pouring out of their funnels. And crossing on all of them, year after year after year, came just about every kind of person you can think of. Pilgrims in their travelling cloaks. Kings and queens and their servants. Soldiers marching off to fight. Farmers taking cows and sheep and horses to market, hooves clattering on the wooden decks. Carts, barrels, baskets of fish, and bundles of letters.

Some of the crossings were not happy ones. When a Scottish king or queen died, their body was sometimes carried across this very water on the ferry, on its way to be buried at the great abbey of Dunfermline. So kings crossed here even after they were dead.

And some crossings were downright scary, because this river does not always behave. Fog can roll in so thick you cannot see the far shore. Storms can whip the water into waves. That is exactly what happened to poor King Alexander all those years ago, the one who was shipwrecked and ended up starting the abbey you are visiting. Crossing water has always been an adventure.

Then, one day in 1964, it all stopped. The big new road bridge opened high overhead, cars could zoom across in a minute or two, and after nine hundred years the ferry boats were finally allowed to rest. So here is something to feel proud of. Almost nobody crosses this water by boat anymore. Everybody just drives over the top on the bridges. But you, today, are doing it the old, old way, the way people did it for nine centuries. You are one of the last ferry passengers on the Queen's own crossing. Give a little wave to all those travellers from long ago.

The Secret Islands of the Forth

As your boat sails along, do not just watch Inchcolm up ahead. Look all around you, because this water is sprinkled with little islands and rocks, and almost every single one is hiding a secret.

One of them is pretending to be a giant battleship. One is nothing but a lighthouse standing right out in the sea, warning ships away from rocks that hide underwater like a trap. One you can actually walk to along a secret path, but only when the sea gets out of the way. And one has huge bridge legs standing right on top of it.

Here is a handy clue for you. Lots of the islands round here have names that start with the word inch. There is Inchcolm, where you are going. There is Inchgarvie, under the bridge. There is Inchmickery, the battleship one. And inch is an old, old word that simply means island. So every time you hear a place beginning with inch, you can whisper to yourself, aha, that is an island.

So keep your eyes peeled and your detective brain switched on. In the next few minutes I am going to help you spot the strangest islands in the whole firth, and tell you the secret hiding on each one. Ready? Let's go island hunting.

The Island That Dressed Up as a Battleship

Out in the water, keep a lookout for a small, low island absolutely covered in lumpy grey concrete buildings. It is called Inchmickery, and it is tiny, but from far away it plays the best trick in the whole firth. Squint at it, and it does not look like an island at all. It looks exactly like a big grey warship sitting on the water, with what seems like a tall bridge in the middle and shapes that look just like gun turrets. Honestly, it is spooky how much it looks like a real battleship.

And for a long, long time, people told a brilliant story about it. They said the soldiers had built it that way on purpose, as a clever disguise. The idea was that enemy submarines and enemy planes would peek at the firth, spot what looked like a mighty battleship on guard, get scared, and stay away. A whole island wearing a battleship costume to trick the enemy. How cool is that?

But wait, because here comes the true part, and it is important to be honest. That story is probably just a legend. When clever historians studied the island really carefully, they could not find any proof that anyone built it to look like a ship on purpose. It turns out the buildings were just plonked wherever the guns could see the water best, and wherever there was room to squeeze in beds for the soldiers. It only ended up looking like a battleship by pure accident.

So which is more amazing? A secret trick island? Or an island that turned into a fake battleship completely by chance, without anyone even trying? I think the accident is the really funny bit. Because even if nobody planned it, that little island has still managed to fool loads and loads of people over the years into thinking it was a warship. Trick or accident, it worked. So as you pass it, have a good long squint. Can you see the battleship hiding in the island? Once you spot it, you will never be able to unsee it.

Islands with Very Strange Names

Now for a quick tour of the weirdest islands and rocks around you, because they have some brilliant secrets and some very silly names.

First, look for a skinny tower that seems to be standing all by itself right in the open sea, with no island under it at all. That is the Oxcars lighthouse. Why put a lighthouse there, in the middle of nowhere? Because just under the surface there hide some really dangerous rocks, sneaky ones you cannot see until

your boat crunches into them, and over the years they have ripped holes in loads of ships. So the lighthouse stands there like a night-time guard, shining out, saying, careful, careful, rocks down here. And here is the fun bit. Some of the rocks nearby are named the Cow and the Calf, as if a stone cow and her stone baby were paddling in the sea.

Next, look under the middle of the big red railway bridge. See that rocky little island the huge bridge legs are standing on? That is Inchgarvie. Long ago it had a real castle on it, and even stranger, it was once used to keep sick people away from everybody else, all alone out on the rock, so their illness could not spread. Imagine being sent to live on a tiny island just because you had a cough.

Then there is Cramond Island, closer to the city, and it has the best trick of all. When the tide goes out, a stone path appears out of the sea, and you can walk all the way to the island on foot. But you have to be quick, because when the tide comes back in, the sea gobbles up the path again. Every year some people forget, dawdle too long, and get stuck out there, and someone has to come and rescue them. So it is a walk-to island, but only if you can beat the sea.

And far, far out toward the open ocean sit two superstar islands you might only just glimpse. One is the Isle of May, home to thousands and thousands of puffins in summer. The other is the Bass Rock, a great lump of stone that looks like it is covered in snow all year round. But it is not snow. It is birds. Tens of thousands of big white seabirds packed together so tightly they turn the whole rock white. So even the islands too far to reach have secrets. This firth is basically a giant puzzle box, made of rocks.